

TAMS MUN I

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Soviet Union

Nine Hours to Midnight: The Dissolution of the USSR, 1991

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Letter from the Chair

Dear delegates,

Welcome to the inaugural session of TAMS Model United Nations, held on 26 September at the Business Leadership Building at the University of North Texas. On behalf of your dais, it is our privilege to chair this committee.

You are not here to write a resolution. You are here to decide whether a country survives.

In roughly nine hours, a group of men in this room intends to place the President of the Soviet Union under house arrest. In two days, the Union Treaty that would refound this state as a voluntary federation is scheduled for signature. In four months — if history is allowed to proceed unmolested — the red flag comes down over the Kremlin and twenty-seven thousand nuclear warheads acquire four new owners.

None of that is fixed. This committee begins the evening *before* the August Coup, and every one of those outcomes is live. What decides which one happens is not eloquence. It is whether you understand what your character actually controls, and whether you are willing to use it before someone else uses theirs on you.

Read your position. Then read what your character *wanted*, which is rarely the same as what your character *said*.

Sincerely,

Your Chair

USSR Crisis · ballot.tams@gmail.com

Letter from the Crisis Director

Dear delegates,

This letter comes from your Crisis Director.

A crisis committee is a machine with two halves. In the room, you debate and vote on public directives. Outside it, in the backroom, my staff and I take the private notes you send us and turn them into consequences — troop movements, arrests, resignations, bank runs, headlines. The half of the committee you cannot see is usually the half that decides the outcome.

Two pieces of advice. First: **be specific**. A note that says "I secure the Kremlin" produces nothing. A note that says "I order the commander of the Kremlin Regiment, by name, to seal the Borovitsky Gate, admit only officers I designate, and report to me hourly by secure line" produces something. Second: **be fast**. This period rewarded whoever acted first and paid for hesitation in territory.

You will find that this committee has no clean solutions. Every path out of August 1991 costs something enormous, and the men and women whose seats you occupy knew that. Play them as people making impossible choices under exhaustion, not as villains or heroes.

I look forward to a fast, ruthless, and genuinely uncertain weekend.

Sincerely,

Your Crisis Director

USSR Crisis · ballot.tams@gmail.com

1. The Inheritance

Oil and Stagnation

The Brezhnev era bought stability with oil. High world crude prices after 1973 funded grain imports, consumer subsidies, and a military establishment consuming somewhere between 15% and 25% of national output — a figure never known with confidence even inside the Politburo. Productivity growth flattened. The *nomenklatura* calcified into a hereditary administrative class. By the early 1980s the Soviet Union was importing food that the Russian Empire had exported.

Then oil collapsed. The 1985–86 price crash removed the hard-currency earnings that had made the system solvent. Every reform attempted after 1985 was attempted inside that hole.

Gorbachev's Wager

Mikhail Gorbachev became General Secretary in March 1985 with a program that evolved from *uskoreniye* (acceleration) to *perestroika* (restructuring) to *glasnost* (openness). His wager was that the socialist system was salvageable — that it was being strangled by a corrupt and immobile bureaucracy, and that opening the press and the ballot would let him mobilize society against that bureaucracy and force reform through.

He was right that the apparatus would resist him. He was wrong about what would happen once society was allowed to speak.

The Unintended Consequences of Glasnost

Each reform corroded a load-bearing wall:

- **The 1987 Law on State Enterprises** granted managers autonomy without creating prices or hard budget constraints. Enterprises raised wages, ignored plan targets, and starved the state budget — producing a monetary overhang with nothing to buy.
- **Glasnost** legitimized public criticism. Revelations about the Terror, about Chernobyl's cover-up, and above all about the secret protocols of the Molotov–Ribbentrop Pact destroyed the Party's moral claim to rule. In the Baltics, the Protocols did something more specific: they established that Soviet rule there was not a rev-

olution but an occupation, and therefore illegal from its first day.

- **The 1989 Congress of People's Deputies elections**, partially free, produced a televised opposition. Sixty percent of the country watched. Party officials were defeated at the polls; Andrei Sakharov was heckled and heckled back on live television.
- **The "Sinatra Doctrine"** — Moscow's decision not to intervene — let Eastern Europe go in the autumn of 1989. If Warsaw and Prague could leave, Vilnius and Kyiv could ask why they could not.

2. The Union Comes Apart

The Nationalities Crisis

The Union was fifteen republics, each with a titular nationality, a language, an intelligentsia, and a constitutional right to secede that no one had ever tested. Between 1986 and 1991 that architecture failed everywhere at once.

Riots in Alma-Ata (1986) after a Russian was appointed to lead Kazakhstan. Nagorno-Karabakh from 1988 — the first sustained inter-republic violence, with pogroms in Sumgait and Baku and an armed conflict between two Union republics that Moscow could neither win nor stop. Tbilisi, April 1989: soldiers with entrenching tools killed civilian demonstrators, radicalizing Georgia in a night. The Baltic Way, August 1989: two million people joined hands across three republics on the fiftieth anniversary of the Pact.

Lithuania declared independence on 11 March 1990. Moscow answered with an economic blockade and, in January 1991, with force — OMON and paratroopers at the Vilnius television tower (fourteen dead) and in Riga. The crack-downs failed twice over: they did not restore control, and they destroyed the reformist coalition that had been protecting Gorbachev from his own right wing.

Dual Power in Russia

The decisive break was **Russia itself**. In March 1990 the Congress repealed Article 6 of the Constitution, ending the Party's guaranteed monopoly

on power. In June 1990 the RSFSR declared *sovereignty* — asserting that Russian law prevailed over Union law on Russian territory, which happened to be three-quarters of the Union's land-mass, half its population, and most of its oil.

Boris Yeltsin, expelled from the leadership in disgrace in 1987, made himself the vehicle for it. He resigned from the Party on live television in July 1990. And on **12 June 1991 he was elected President of Russia with 57% of the vote** in the first free presidential election in Russian history.

Gorbachev had never faced a national electorate. Yeltsin had. **That asymmetry of legitimacy is the most important single fact in this committee.**

Economics in Freefall

The **500 Days Plan** (Shatalin–Yavlinsky), a rapid marketization program, was endorsed by the Russian republic and then abandoned by Gorbachev in October 1990 in favor of an incoherent compromise. It was the moment many reformers concluded he would never actually choose.

Prime Minister Valentin Pavlov's January 1991 withdrawal of 50- and 100-ruble notes, announced with three days' notice, destroyed household savings and whatever trust remained. April price rises triggered strikes. Coal miners in the Donbas and Kuzbass struck through the spring and by summer were demanding Gorbachev's resignation outright. Shops were empty. Harvests rotted for want of fuel and trucks. The Union budget was funded by printing money and by quiet sales against gold reserves that had fallen to a few hundred tons.

3. The Eve

The March Referendum

On **17 March 1991** a Union-wide referendum asked whether citizens favored preserving the USSR as a "renewed federation of equal sovereign republics." Roughly 76% of participants said yes.

The mandate was weaker than the number suggests. Six republics — Lithuania, Latvia, Estonia, Georgia, Armenia, Moldova — boycotted entirely. Russia appended a second question creating a directly elected Russian presidency, which

passed and produced Yeltsin. Ukraine appended its own question on sovereignty, which also passed. Every side claimed the result.

Novo-Ogaryovo

The referendum produced the **Novo-Ogaryovo negotiations** between Gorbachev and the republic leaders, and by August a draft **Union Treaty** establishing a Union of Sovereign States. Its terms: republics control their own natural resources and taxation and remit revenue to the center at rates they themselves set; the center retains defense, foreign policy, and a coordinating role; the Union becomes, in substance, a confederation.

To the reformers it was the only formula that could hold anything together. To the Union ministries, the Party apparatus, the military-industrial complex, and the security organs, it was a document that abolished their institutions, their budgets, and their country by signature.

18 August 1991

The Treaty is scheduled for signature on 20 August. Gorbachev left for his dacha at Foros in Crimea on 4 August. The men who intend to stop the Treaty have until the 20th.

On 17 August a group met at a KGB facility outside Moscow and agreed to act. On the evening of **18 August**, a delegation boarded an aircraft for Crimea.

That is where this committee opens.

4. The Strategic Picture

Nuclear custody. Approximately 27,000 warheads sit on the territory of Russia, Ukraine, Belarus, and Kazakhstan. Launch authority runs through the *Cheget* briefcases held by the President, the Minister of Defence, and the Chief of the General Staff. Any transfer of authority — coup, resignation, dissolution — raises a question with no legal answer: **who holds the button, and who believes they do?** START I was signed on 31 July, three weeks ago. Washington's overriding interest in everything that follows is that it happen without a loose warhead.

The army's loyalty is conditional. Conscripts are drawn from every republic. Officers

have unpaid salaries, no housing, and the humiliation of the withdrawal from Germany ahead of them. Units have already refused orders in the Caucasus. Nobody in this room knows whether the Taman and Kantemirov divisions will fire on Russian civilians in Moscow, and nobody can find out without trying.

The Party is no longer the state, but it owns things. Buildings, cash, foreign accounts, media, sanatoria, and a personnel network inside every enterprise in the country.

Foreign leverage exists and is contingent. The G7 declined large-scale assistance at the London summit in July, offering IMF association instead. Western credit is available only to a government the West regards as legitimate and non-violent — which makes the use of force in Moscow an economic decision as much as a political one.

5. Questions to Consider

1. Does the Union Treaty get signed, killed, or renegotiated — and by whom?
2. If the center uses force, what happens on the *second* day, when the force has to be sustained?
3. Who has custody of nuclear weapons under any successor arrangement, and how is that made credible to Washington?
4. Can the ruble survive as a single currency across independent republics, and who controls emission?
5. What happens to the 25 million ethnic Russians living outside the RSFSR?
6. Can the Baltics be released without conceding the principle to Ukraine — and is Ukraine's departure survivable for any Union at all?
7. Is there a version of the Soviet state that survives, and what is the minimum it must contain?

6. Committee Character Positions

Union Leadership (5)

Mikhail S. Gorbachev — President of the USSR; General Secretary of the CPSU. The

author of everything that has happened and the prisoner of it. Gorbachev still believes the Union can be saved by a treaty, that the Party can be reformed rather than abolished, and that he personally is indispensable to both — a belief no longer widely shared. He has spent eighteen months triangulating between reformers and hardliners and has lost the trust of both: Yakovlev and Shevardnadze have left him, and the men he appointed to run the security ministries are the men now flying to Crimea. He commands enormous formal authority and very little real force. His legitimacy comes from the Party and from abroad, never from a Soviet electorate.

Gennady I. Yanayev — Vice President of the USSR. A trade union functionary elevated to the vice presidency in December 1990 over the objections of the Congress, which rejected him once before Gorbachev forced the appointment through. He is constitutionally next in line should the President become unable to perform his duties — a clause that is about to become the most important sentence in Soviet law. Yanayev is not a leader of anything; he is a legally necessary signature, and everyone in the room knows it, including him.

Anatoly I. Lukyanov — Chairman of the Supreme Soviet of the USSR. Gorbachev's law school classmate and one of his oldest political associates, and by 1991 a quiet opponent of the Union Treaty, which he regards as constitutionally void because the Supreme Soviet has not approved it. Lukyanov controls the legislature and therefore the only body that can lend a change of government a colour of legality. He is a lawyer by instinct: he prefers to be the man who ratifies an accomplished fact rather than the man who creates one.

Valentin S. Pavlov — Prime Minister of the USSR. Author of the January 1991 currency confiscation and of the April price rises, and in June he asked the Supreme Soviet to transfer emergency economic powers from the President to himself — an attempted constitutional coup that failed publicly. Pavlov believes the Union Treaty will destroy the all-Union economy by handing taxation to the republics. He controls the Council of Ministers, the ministries of the industrial complex, and the state banking system.

Yevgeny M. Primakov — member of the Presidential Council. An Arabist, academic, and intelligence hand with a career built on being useful to every leadership without belonging to any faction. Primakov's instincts are for the survival of the state rather than of the ideology, and he has better foreign contacts than almost anyone else in the room. He is the person most likely to be trusted as an intermediary by two sides who do not trust each other, and he knows it.

Security and Armed Forces (6)

Vladimir A. Kryuchkov — Chairman of the KGB. The organizing intelligence behind the effort to stop the Treaty. Kryuchkov has spent two years feeding Gorbachev reports on Western subversion and internal enemies, has surveilled Yeltsin and the democratic movement, and commands the most capable institution in the Soviet Union: foreign and domestic intelligence, the Alpha Group, the border troops, and the communications systems everyone else depends on. His weakness is that the KGB is an instrument of information and coercion, not of governing — and he has no plan for the morning after.

Dmitry T. Yazov — Minister of Defence, Marshal of the Soviet Union. A career soldier promoted past better-connected rivals and personally loyal to Gorbachev until the Treaty made him choose between his President and his army. Yazov commands the largest military on earth and is deeply reluctant to point it at Soviet civilians; he saw what Tbilisi and Vilnius cost. He is the single most consequential undecided actor in the committee, because nothing the hardliners plan works without the army and nothing Yeltsin plans survives if the army moves decisively.

Boris K. Pugo — Minister of Internal Affairs (MVD). A Latvian Party official and former head of the Latvian KGB, appointed to the MVD in December 1990 when Bakatin was dismissed for insufficient firmness. Pugo commands the internal troops and the OMON detachments that carried out the Baltic crackdowns. He has no illusions about what his forces are for and no constituency outside the apparatus — for him, the Union Treaty ends both his ministry and his country.

Yevgeny I. Shaposhnikov — Commander-in-Chief of the Soviet Air Forces. A reform-minded senior officer, more sympathetic to the new Russian leadership than most of the high command, and privately contemptuous of the idea of using the armed forces against the population. He controls military transport aviation — which is how paratroopers get anywhere — and long-range aviation, one leg of the nuclear triad. If the officer corps splits, Shaposhnikov is where the split begins.

Pavel S. Grachev — Commander of the Airborne Forces (VDV). An Afghanistan veteran commanding the most mobile and reliable force in the Soviet military, and therefore the man both sides need. Grachev has been asked by his superiors to prepare for operations in Moscow and has separately been in contact with the Russian leadership. His personal calculation — which side is going to win, and which side will remember what he did — is the hinge on which control of Moscow physically turns.

Alexander I. Lebed — Deputy Commander of the Airborne Forces. Blunt, popular with his soldiers, and openly disdainful of politicians of every faction. Lebed has commanded troops in Tbilisi and Baku and has drawn from it the conviction that the army is used by cowards and blamed afterward. He commands the Tula division, the unit closest to Moscow. He is the sort of officer who decides for himself what an order means.

Boris N. Yeltsin — President of the RSFSR. The only official in the Soviet Union with a popular mandate, and the one man in the room who benefits from a crisis. Yeltsin's strategy has been consistent for two years: strengthen Russia at the expense of the center, on the theory that whatever remains of the Union will end up in Russian hands. He is impulsive, physically brave, tactically brilliant under pressure and erratic when not, and he commands the Russian government, the Russian parliament building, the Moscow city administration through his allies, and — most importantly — the willingness of a great many Muscovites to come into the street when he asks.

Alexander V. Rutskoy — Vice President of the RSFSR. A decorated combat pilot shot down twice in Afghanistan, elected on Yeltsin's ticket to

give it patriotic and military credibility. Ruskoy is a communist by conviction and a Russian nationalist by temperament, and he is with Yeltsin because of the man rather than the program. He carries a pistol and has more credibility with serving officers than any other figure on the Russian side.

Leonid M. Kravchuk — Chairman of the Supreme Soviet of the Ukrainian SSR. The former Party ideology secretary who has repositioned himself, with remarkable agility, as the guarantor of Ukrainian sovereignty. Kravchuk's method is to concede nothing and commit to nothing: he has extracted concession after concession in the Novo-Ogaryovo talks while keeping Ukraine's signature in reserve. Ukraine is 52 million people, the Union's agricultural base, much of its heavy industry, the Black Sea Fleet, and roughly 1,900 strategic warheads. **No Union survives Ukraine's departure**, and Kravchuk is aware of exactly how much that fact is worth.

Nursultan A. Nazarbayev — President of the Kazakh SSR. The most committed republican supporter of a renewed Union, and for concrete reasons: Kazakhstan's economy is fused with Russia's, its northern oblasts are majority Russian, and it hosts Semipalatinsk, Baikonur, and a large share of the Soviet strategic arsenal. He has been Gorbachev's most reliable partner at Novo-Ogaryovo and was reportedly to be offered the Union premiership. Nazarbayev's problem is that he needs a Union and cannot create one alone.

If registration runs over, expand to 20 with:
Alexander N. Yakovlev (architect of glasnost, recently resigned from the Party), **Mikhail A. Moiseyev** (Chief of the General Staff, holder of a nuclear briefcase), **Vadim V. Bakatin** (former Interior Minister, dismissed for refusing to use force against the republics), **Stanislav S. Shushkevich** (Byelorussian SSR), and **Ivan S. Silayev** (Chairman of the RSFSR Council of Ministers).

7. The Historical Baseline — What Happens If You Do Nothing

The committee is free to diverge from history, but every delegate should know the actual sequence, because it is what the backroom will default to wherever you fail to act.

19 August. At 06:00 state media announce that Gorbachev is "unable to perform his duties for health reasons" and that a State Committee on the State of Emergency (GKChP) has assumed power — Yanayev, Pavlov, Kryuchkov, Yazov, Pugo among its eight members. Tanks enter Moscow. The GKChP's press conference is a catastrophe: Yanayev's hands visibly shake on live television. Yeltsin reaches the Russian parliament (the White House), climbs onto Tank No. 110 of the Taman Division, and declares the coup unconstitutional. Crowds begin building barricades.

20 August. The Union Treaty signing does not happen — the coup has succeeded in its one concrete aim, permanently. Perhaps 50,000–150,000 Muscovites surround the White House. Major military figures begin quietly refusing orders. An assault plan against the White House (codenamed *Grom*) is prepared; Alpha Group officers indicate they will not execute it.

21 August. Three young men die in an underpass confrontation with an armoured column — the coup's only Moscow fatalities. The assault never comes. By afternoon the GKChP orders troops out of Moscow; a delegation flies to Foros to see Gorbachev, who refuses to receive them. Kryuchkov is arrested that night; Pugo dies by suicide before arrest.

22–24 August. Gorbachev returns to a country that no longer exists as he left it. Yeltsin, in front of cameras, forces him to read aloud the minutes of the cabinet meeting in which his own ministers backed the coup. Yeltsin suspends the Russian Communist Party. Gorbachev resigns as General Secretary on the 24th. The same day, **Ukraine declares independence**, subject to a December referendum.

September–November. The republics stampede: declarations of independence from nearly all. The State Council recognizes Baltic independence on 6 September. The Union economy ceases to function as a single unit; republics stop remitting revenue entirely.

1 December. Ukraine's referendum: **90.3% for independence** on 84% turnout — majorities in every region, including Crimea. Any theoretical Union dies with this vote.

8 December. Yeltsin, Kravchuk, and

Shushkevich meet at a hunting lodge in the Belovezha forest and sign an agreement stating that "the USSR as a subject of international law and a geopolitical reality ceases to exist," founding the CIS. Nazarbayev, invited by phone, declines to fly in. Gorbachev learns afterward.

21 December. The Alma-Ata Protocol brings eleven republics into the CIS. **25 December.** Gorbachev resigns; the red flag over the Kremlin comes down at 19:32. The nuclear briefcase is transferred to Yeltsin. **26 December.** The Supreme Soviet votes itself and the USSR out of existence.

For delegates: everything above is contingent — the committee begins on 18 August, and nothing after that date is scripted.

8. Rules of Crisis Procedure

No Speakers List by default. Debate runs in near-continuous moderated caucus, interrupted by crisis updates from the Crisis Director.

Public directives are actions taken by the committee as a body: debated, amended, and passed by simple majority. Written as numbered operative clauses with no preambulatory clauses, signed by sponsors.

Private directives are notes to the backroom describing an action you take using your own portfolio's resources. Not debated, not voted, not public. Three to six sentences. State what you are doing, with what resources, through whom, and what you expect to happen.

Communiqués are messages to parties outside the room — a foreign government, a military district commander, a newspaper editor.

Portfolio powers are the binding constraint. The Chairman of the KGB does not command tank divisions. The President of Russia does not command the Strategic Rocket Forces. The Minister of Defence does not control the money supply. Directives that assume powers you do not have will fail, and will fail publicly.

The dual-power problem. Nearly every institution in this room is duplicated — a Union government and a Russian one, Union law and republic law each claiming supremacy over the same territory and the same people. Exploiting or resolv-

ing that duplication is the central strategic game of the committee.

Character, not caricature. You may depart from what your historical figure actually did — that is the point of an alternate history — but you must depart from it for reasons your character would have had.

9. Sources and Further Reading

Books

- Serhii Plokhy, *The Last Empire: The Final Days of the Soviet Union* (2014) — the best single account of these months
- Vladislav Zubok, *Collapse: The Fall of the Soviet Union* (2021)
- Stephen Kotkin, *Armageddon Averted: The Soviet Collapse, 1970–2000*
- Chris Miller, *The Struggle to Save the Soviet Economy*
- Archie Brown, *The Gorbachev Factor*
- David Remnick, *Lenin's Tomb* — reportage from inside the collapse

Primary documents

- The draft Union Treaty, published in *Pravda*, 15 August 1991
- The GKChP "Appeal to the Soviet People" and Resolution No. 1, 19 August 1991
- Yeltsin's Decree No. 59 declaring the emergency committee unconstitutional
- The Belovezha Accords (8 December 1991) and the Alma-Ata Protocol (21 December 1991)
- **The National Security Archive at George Washington University** hosts declassified US and Soviet documents from 1991, free online. This is the best source for portfolio-specific detail, and the dais will notice delegates who have used it.

Note on research. Your single most valuable hour will be spent reading about *your own character* rather than about the period generally. Find out what they controlled, who they trusted, and what they were afraid of.